

INDIAN DEMOGRAPHICS & POPULATION TRENDS: UPSC PRELIMS 2026.

REAL-TIME UPDATE & KEY CONCEPTS



1. TFR PARADOX & REPRODUCTIVE AGENCY



- **INDIA'S TFR:** Dropped to 2.0 (2025/26), below replacement level (2.1).
- **KEY CONCEPT:** 'Reproductive Agency Crisis' (UNFPA SWOP 2025 Report).
- **Issue:** Dual gap—unintended pregnancies vs. rising infertility (25-30M affected).
- **'DEMOGRAPHIC WINTER':** Sharp birth decline in Southern/Western states, causing future labor and fiscal concerns.



2. POPULATION AGING: THE 'SILVER ECONOMY'



- **ELDERLY POPULATION (60+):** Projected to exceed 20% by 2047 (crossed 150M in 2026).
- **FEMINIZATION OF AGING:** High sex ratio (e.g., 1065 females/1000 males in 60+ group), with many widows lacking assets.
- **WELFARE INITIATIVES:**
 - Atal Vayo Abhyuday Yojana (AVYAY):** Grants for Senior Citizen Homes, Continuous Care Homes (IPSR).
 - Elderline (14567):** National toll-free helpline (info, guidance, support).



3. DEMOGRAPHIC DIVIDEND: THE '2041 PEAK'

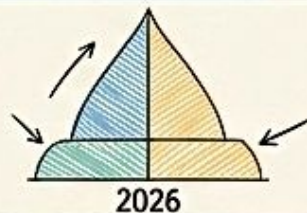


- **CURRENT STATUS:** 65% of population under 35; ~68% working-age (15-64).
- **2041 PIVOT:** Working-age population peaks, then contracts.
- **SHIFT:** Need for a 'Productivity Dividend' (Economic Survey).
- **Focus:** Gig workforce (1.2 cr in 2025) & Female Labor Force Participation for 7%+ GDP.

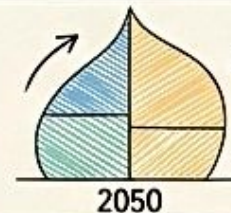


4. COMPARATIVE SUMMARY FOR PRELIMS

FEATURE	TREND/VALUE (2025-26)	SIGNIFICANCE
TFR	1.9	Population stabilization/decline.
MEDIAN AGE	28.2 Years	India is 'young' (vs. China 39, Japan 49).
ELDERLY POPULATION	~11-12%	Rising 'Old-age Dependency Ratio' (target 30 by 2050).
REPLACEMENT LEVEL	2.1	TFR needed for constant population size.



2026



2050

DEMOGRAPHIC DIVERGENCE

COMPREHENSIVE NOTEBOOK: WOMEN & GENDER ISSUES



FOR UPSC PRELIMS 2026

FOR UPSC PRELIMS 2026

WOMEN AND GENDER ISSUES: KEY INITIATIVES & DEVELOPMENTS

1 e-SafeHER PROGRAMME

- Launched by **MeitY** (Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology)
- Goal: Safe participation of **1 MILLION rural women** in digital ecosystem
- By 2029
- Focus: Digital literacy, online safety, protection from harassment & deepfakes, safe digital finance



2 MENSTRUAL HEALTH & ARTICLE 21

- Legal debates gained traction in early 2026
- Focus: **Menstrual Leave** as a fundamental right under Article 21
- **Right to Life and Personal Liberty** including **Right to Live with Dignity**
- Constitutional Links: Art. 42 (just & humane conditions of work, maternity relief), Art. 15(3) (special provisions for women)



3 SHREYAS-SC SCHEME (Top Class Education)



- Significant funds released in 2025
- Focus: **Top Class Education** for SC girl students in premier institutions
- Mandatory **30% reservation** for SC girl students
- Financial assistance for tuition, living expenses, laptops



→ Nodal Ministry: Social Justice and Empowerment

4 WOMANIYA INITIATIVE

- Focus: Building **inclusive market access** for women entrepreneurs



- Leverages **GeM** (Government e-Marketplace)
- Enables direct selling to Government ministries & departments
- Bypasses intermediaries
- Benefits **Women Self-Help Groups (WSHGs)**



'VULNERABLE SECTIONS & SOCIAL JUSTICE (UPSC PRELIMS 2026)



TRANSGENDER RIGHTS: EVOLUTION AND PROTECTIONS



- **Focus Area: NALSA vs UoI (2014)**
 - Right to Self-Identification (Art 21), Third Gender recognition
- **The Transgender Persons Act, 2019**
 - Key provisions: Identity Certificate (DM issue)
 - National Council (NCTP), non-discrimination
 - 2026 Amendment focus (discussion on horizontal reservation, streamlined process)
- **SMILE Scheme (Garima Greh)**



SANITATION WORKERS: TOWARDS A MECHANISED ECOSYSTEM



- **Focus: Complete eradication of Manual Scavenging**
- **MS Act, 2013: Prohibition**
- **Transition to NAMASTE Scheme (National Action for Mechanised Sanitation Ecosystem) - Jt Ministry initiative (MSJE & MoHUA)**
 - Zero fatalities goal
- **Features: Capital subsidy for equipment, training, health insurance**
- **SC Mandate: Increased compensation for sewer deaths (₹30 Lakhs)**



DENOTIFIED, NOMADIC, & SEMI-NOMADIC TRIBES (DNTs, NTs, SNTs)



- **Historical context: Formerly under Criminal Tribes Act 1871**
- **Key bodies: DWBDNC (Board)**
- **Major Scheme: SEED (Scheme for Economic Empowerment of DNTs). Components:**
 1. Free Coaching (exams)
 2. Health Insurance (PM-JAY)
 3. Livelihood Support
 4. Housing Assistance (PMAY)
- **Focus on profiling and socio-economic support**



MINORITY WELFARE: PMJVK RESTRUCTURING



- **Minority definition (not in Constitution, under NCM Act: 6 notified groups)**
- **Scheme: Pradhan Mantri Jan Vikas Karyakram (PMJVK)**
- **Shift: From Area Development to Human Development**
 - Expanded to all districts in India
 - Focus Sectors (80% funds): Education, Health, Skill Development
- **Constitutional context (Art 29, 30)**



URBANISATION & MIGRATION: ECONOMIC & SUSTAINABLE TRANSITIONS



SECTION 1

CITY ECONOMIC REGIONS (CERs) | BUDGET 2026-27

- **Concept:** Mapping cities as 'engines of growth', leveraging economic agglomeration.
- **Allocation:** ₹5,000 Crore per CER over 5 years.
- **Target:** Focus on Tier-2 & Tier-3 Cities, decentralizing growth.
- **Goal:** Modern infrastructure tailored to local 'growth drivers'.



SECTION 3

SUSTAINABLE URBANISM & MOBILITY



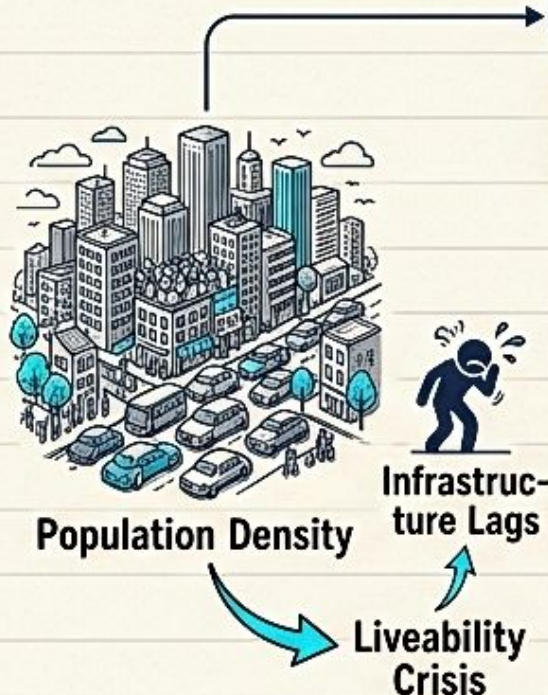
PM-eBUS SEWA: PPP model to deploy 10,000 electric buses, targeting cities without organized bus services.



AMRUT 2.0: 'Water Secure' cities via circular economy; 100% sewerage in 500 cities.



SMART CITIES MISSION (2026 Shift): Moving to 'Integrated Command and Control Centers' (ICCCs) for real-time city management.



SECTION 2

THE 'URBAN PARADOX' | ECONOMIC SURVEY 2026

Key Drivers:

Infrastructure Lags: High housing costs, sanitation, waste management.

Geometric Inefficiency: Low Floor Space Index (FSI) leads to sprawl, high costs.

Fiscal Constraint: Indian cities raise less than 0.6% of GDP in own revenues; over-reliance on transfers.



PRO-TIP / KEY FACT

UPSC 2026 KEY TAKEAWAY

SPATIAL PLANNING: Economic Survey 2026 mandates every million-plus city to prepare a 20-year City Spatial and Economic Plan, updated every 5 years.

'ABHISHA AI
by Abhishek Pathak

SOCIAL SECTOR: HEALTH, EDUCATION & POVERTY (2025-26)



HUMAN DEVELOPMENT INDEX (HDI) | 2025 REPORT

- **India's Rank:** 130th out of 193 countries (Medium Category).
- **Inequality-adjusted HDI (IHDI):** ~31% loss in value due to disparities (health, education, income).
- **Key Drivers:** Gini Coefficient and gender pay gap remain hurdles.
- Life expectancy ~72 years.



NEP 2020: VIKSIT BHARAT SHIKSHA ADHISHTHAN BILL 2025

- **Regulatory Overhaul:** Bill establishes single unified regulator for higher ed. Subsumes UGC, AICTE, NCTE.
- **Structure:** Featuring three councils: Regulatory, Accreditation, and Standards.
- **Exclusions:** Legal and Medical education remain outside.



GLOBAL TB REPORT 2025: INDIA'S PROGRESS

- **Incidence Reduction:** 21% drop in new cases (nearly double global pace).
- **The Milestone Miss:** Despite progress, missed "End TB" 2025 milestones.
- **Treatment:** Coverage hit 92% with 90% success rate under Pradhan Mantri TB Mukht Bharat Abhiyan.



POVERTY FREE MILESTONE: DHARMADOM (KERALA)

- **The Achievement:** Dharmadom became India's first "Extreme Poverty-Free" constituency.
- **Model:** Local survey focused on Nutritious Food, Healthcare, Housing, and Income.
- **Larger Goal:** Kerala's 2026 goal to uplift 5 lakh families, eradicating absolute poverty.

ABHISHA AI | UPSC 2026 KEY TAKEAWAY

- **Viksit Bharat Goals:** Legislative reforms (e.g., Shiksha Adhishthan Bill) align with India's 2047 vision for "Ease of Education" and "Ease of Doing Research".

DIGITAL SOCIETY & TECH: THE 2026 FRONTIER



DIGITAL LITERACY: THE KERALA MILESTONE

- **Ernakulam:** 1st fully digitally literate district in Kerala, driving state-level status.
- **Digi Kerala Project:** Trained ~22 lakh individuals (99.98% target) to bridge the digital divide.
- **Impact:** Enables senior citizens and marginalized groups to access e-governance, welfare schemes, and services without intermediaries.



ETHICS OF SPORTS GENOMICS

- **Gujarat Sports Genomics Programme:** Maps DNA to identify traits linked to speed, endurance, and strength. Emerging Trend.
- **Ethical Debate:** Genetic Discrimination, 'Designer Athletes' concerns, and Data Privacy of sensitive genetic info, requiring robust regulation.



AI GOVERNANCE & EDUCATION



- **Bharat Bodhan AI Conclave 2026:** Organized by Ministry of Education to build the 'Bharat Education AI Stack' (Open, interoperable framework).
- **New Delhi Declaration on AI Impact (Feb 2026):** Focus on 'Democratic Diffusion of AI' and affordable access.
- **Sovereign Capacity:** India expanding compute with 20,000 GPUs for local AI development.

ABHISHA AI | UPSC 2026 KEY TAKEAWAY

- **Viksit Bharat Goals:** Shift toward 'Sovereign AI' and 'Green Highway Indices' marks India's transition to high-precision, technology-monitored development.



NATIONAL HIGHWAYS GREEN COVER INDEX (NH-GCI) 2025-26



- **Institutional Collaboration:** Joint report by NHAI and ISRO (NRSC).
- **The Tech:** Uses satellite-detected chlorophyll content for quantitative assessment along 30,000 km.
- **Purpose:** Data-driven focus on 'percentage of green cover' for sustainable highways.

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